



a men's team silver in 2018 — but his Olympic dream seemed further away. The tattoo, meant as motivation, became a constant reminder of an unattainable goal.

That changed on Tuesday.

The now 30-year-old received a call from a friend, later confirmed on the World Archery website — compound archery will be a medal event at the Los Angeles Olympics 2028. Though the discipline will feature only one medal event — the mixed team category — Rajat is ecstatic. "I couldn't even sleep all night that day," he laughs.

Despite his accomplishments, Rajat admits the lack of Olympic recognition always stung. "At the end of the day, no matter how much I'd accomplished in compound archery, I always felt the itch that I wasn't competing in an Olympic medal event. I knew in the back of my mind that compound wouldn't ever be as popular as an Olympic event," he says.

Out of focus: Compound archery's absence from the Olympics meant that despite India's success in the sport, it wasn't prioritised in funding and resources. GETTY IMAGES

Low priority

It wasn't just about popularity. The sport's absence from the Olympics meant that despite India's success — winning three out of five gold medals in the compound events at the 2023 World Championships and sweeping five gold medals at the 2022 Asian Games — compound archery wasn't prioritised in funding and resources.

"Compound archers have been winning medals at the World Championships since 2014. Our archers win medals at the Asian Games when our recurve archers haven't. But the moment the Asian Games end, we would be told by the authorities that 'okay, now your competitions are over, and the priority is the recurve team for the Olympics.' It was like we were stepchildren!" says Jiwanjot Singh, longtime coach of the Indian compound team.

Rajat acknowledges this disparity. "No compound archer has any sponsor. We are either self-funded or supported by the government.

Until the Asian Games, we were supported just like the recurve archers, but after that, the focus shifted to them. But *uske baad Olympics bhagwan hota hai* (But after that, the Olympics is like God!). Sometimes, when we had to meet an officer after the Asian Games, they'd ask us what our next big tournament was, and it would get very awkward because compound archery wasn't part of either the Olympics or the Commonwealth Games," he says.

This lack of support wasn't unique to India. Jiwanjot, who briefly worked in Canada, saw the same pattern there. "Even in Canada, I noticed that the compound archers didn't get anywhere near the kind of support that recurve archers did," he says.

This scenario is likely to change now. "It's great news (that compound archery will be part of the Olympics). Compound archers will get the best possible support, on par with what is provided to recurve archers," says NS Johal, CEO of the government's Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS). According to

Target identified: With the discipline's inclusion in the Olympics, Rajat Chauhan sees an opportunity he cannot miss.

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